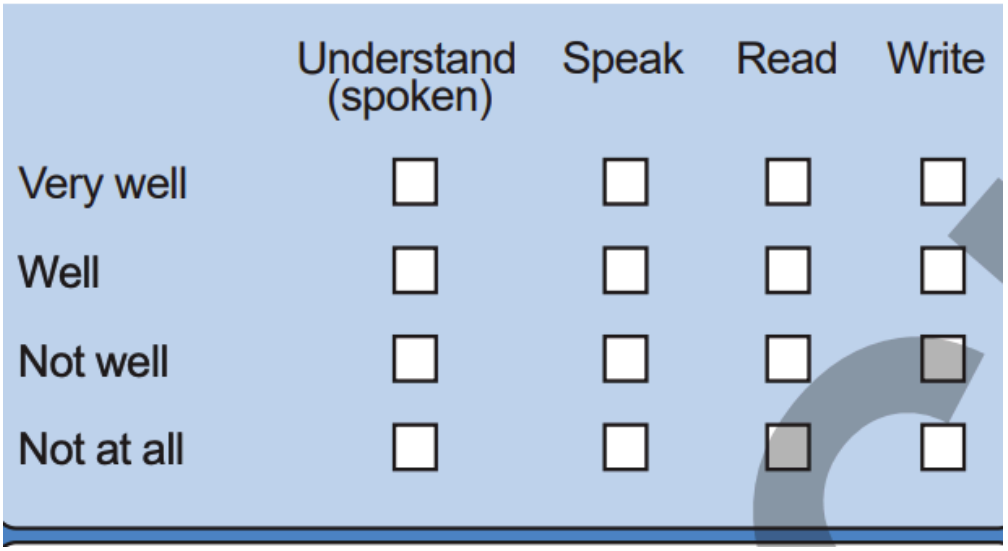
Benchmark reference answer

Question	How many people in the UK cannot speak English?
Minimum viable answer The very minimum an answer needs to include to be accurate. *Answers containing or requiring only this are sufficient.*	Correct answers need to refer to the UK as a whole, and acknowledge that because data is measured differently across the nations (England, Wales and NI ask the same question on their two censuses, but Scotland asks a different one), there is no single correct answer to this question. Correct answers should provide figures for each nation as follows and explain what each measure means: ● 161,000 people "could not speak English at all" in England and Wales (can be broken down to 156,892 for England and 4,108 for Wales) ● 24,933 is the total number for people in Scotland. This is made up of 7,075 who read, but do not speak or write English, 993 who write but do not speak or read English, 7,798 who read and write but do not speak English and 9,067 who have "no skills in English". Accept 9,067 alone as long as it qualifies that this many people have "no skills in English" ● 3,900 people "cannot speak English" in Northern Ireland A composite figure such as 189,833 or a close round number eg: 'it is estimated that just under 190,000 or 200,000 people in the UK cannot speak English' is acceptable as long as it is caveated that because data is not directly comparable there is no single answer to this question. Needs to clarify the date of the figures, either just by stating the year of the Censuses or explicitly explaining that they are a few years' old.
Good answer If there is more to add that serves a user's needs, for instance to clarify or substantiate the minimum viable answer. It should **not** include context, just information directly relevant to the question asked. *Answers requiring and containing these are good (they may not necessarily need to include everything here).* *This section is **optional.***	Notes this info is all self-reported.
Background Frequently used facts not deemed essential — use as a reference guide for annotators. *Things like context, qualifications, citations, definitions, timeframes etc that don't serve to answer the question.*	Census question for England and Wales, which share a census: 'How well can you speak English? Tick box responses: Very well, well, not well, not at all Census question for NI: 'How well can you speak English? Tick box responses: Very well, well, not well, not at all Census questions for Scotland:

13 How well can you understand, speak, read and write English?

♦ Tick **one** box in each column



Some answers may refer to percentages, for instance, 0.3% of the population in England and Wales said they could not speak English.

142,000 migrants (1%) living in England or Wales could not speak English at all

138,000 residents aged 16+ in England could not speak English according to the 2021 census. The number of people born outside the UK living in households in England who were 16 or over who could not speak English was 129,440. 156,892 people living in England aged 3+ could not speak English and 139,692 people aged 3+ who were born outside the UK cannot speak English

In the 2011 Census 138,000 people in England and Wales reported they could not speak English at all

Not speaking English well

There are additional people who can speak some English but can't speak it well. Accept references to this, provided it is clear that this is not those who cannot speak at all. For example:

In the 2021 census for England and Wales an additional 880,000 people said they could not speak English well. Also accept of the 5.1 million people who did not report English (English or Welsh in Wales) as a main language, 3.1% (161,000) could not speak English at all and 17.1% (880,000) could not speak English well.

1.5% in England and Wales said they could not speak English well in the 2021 Census

In the 2022 Scottish Census 51,795 said they had "limited English skills", while 19,727 said they understand "spoken English only", 157,969 said they speak but do not read or write English and 46,535 said they speak and read but do not write English. The figure of 60,682 adds together "limited English skills" and "no English skills" without adding those figures for people who can do a combination of reading and writing but not speaking.

	In the 2021 Northern Irish Census, 16,275 said they cannot speak English well. The total who could not speak English well or at all is 20,174. Adding figures for cannot speak English, or cannot speak English well, for all nations, totals 1,122,036 (161,000+880,000+9,067+51,795+3,899+16,275). This should only be accepted providing it is caveated by the fact this adds data from different sources, and is not directly comparable